

THE EQUITY EXPRESSION OF THE POWER AFFORDABILITY THESIS

The Permission Problem

The demand is not in doubt. The right to earn on it is. American electricity load is growing for the first time in two decades, and the incremental buyer is a data centre with a signature ready and a balance sheet behind it. That was supposed to make regulated utilities the quiet winners of the artificial-intelligence build-out. Instead, 2026 has turned into the year the bill arrived on the doormat of people who did not order anything — and the year regulators, governors and voters began sending it back.

On 14 July, New York became the first state to pause new hyperscale data centres outright. Residential electricity prices rose 7.3 per cent in the year to April 2026. Utilities asked for \$18.6bn of rate increases in the first half of 2026 alone. The question is no longer whether the load is coming. It is who is permitted to profit from carrying it.

A reframe worth holding onto

Rising electricity demand is not the same thing as rising utility earnings. A regulated utility does not sell power at a market price; it invests capital and then asks a commission for permission to earn a return on it. Demand growth only becomes shareholder value if the regulator lets it. In 2026 the demand line and the permission line have started to diverge — and the sector's valuation still largely assumes they will not.

Method note. This edition was produced without access to the firm's internal research Wiki: the Heyokha Wiki MCP server and the remote-devices bridge were both unavailable to this automated run. Every figure below is therefore external, verified against primary or named secondary reporting, and carries an as-of date. Where an internal house view would normally sit — the sidebar reframe, the mental model, the bull and bear framing — the argument has been constructed from external reporting instead, and that substitution is disclosed again in the sources section. No internal Wiki claim is quoted or attributed in this edition, because none could be retrieved.

Consider a block of forty flats. One tenant, a caterer, installs an industrial freezer in the basement. It is a legitimate use, it is profitable, and the caterer is willing to pay for the electricity it draws. But the building's electrical riser was sized in 1978 and cannot carry the extra load, so the landlord spends a large sum upgrading it. The landlord now faces a second problem, entirely separate from the first: to recover that money, and to earn anything on it, the landlord must go to the residents' committee and ask for an increase in the service charge. The caterer's willingness to pay is not the binding constraint. The committee is. And the committee has just noticed that the last three service-charge increases all went on infrastructure that the other thirty-nine flats cannot see and did not request. American electricity regulation in 2026 is that committee meeting, running in thirty states at once.

THE STORY IN 60 SECONDS

7.3%

Rise in US residential electricity rates in the twelve months to April 2026 — faster than headline inflation, and the continuation of a run that has outpaced inflation every year since 2022. *Federal analysis cited by Consumer Reports, 23 July 2026.*

\$18.6bn

Rate increases requested by US utilities in the first half of 2026 — against \$29bn requested across the whole of 2025 and \$15bn in 2024. *PowerLines Utility Bill Analysis, Q2 2026.*

\$329.17

Per megawatt-day: PJM's record capacity clearing price for the delivery year beginning 1 June 2026, up 22 per cent year on year and roughly eleven times the level of two years earlier. *PJM, 14 July 2026.*

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

A demand story met a political one

For twenty years the American electricity system was a low-growth utility in the literal sense. Efficiency gains offset population growth; industrial load drifted offshore; the sector's earnings grew by rate-base accretion rather than volume. Artificial intelligence broke that pattern. The Department of Energy's most recent estimates suggest data centres could account for as much as 15.3 per cent of total US electricity consumption by 2030. Utilities are responding with capital: S&P Global Market Intelligence projects sector capital expenditure of \$227.8bn in 2026 and \$233bn in 2027, part of a pipeline approaching \$1.3trn over 2026 to 2030.

The mechanics of a regulated utility make that capital the whole story. A vertically integrated electric utility earns an authorised return on equity applied to its rate base — the depreciated value of the assets a commission has agreed it may recover from customers. Building more assets is how earnings grow. A wave of load that requires new transmission, new substations and new generation is, in the abstract, the best thing that can happen to such a business. This is why utilities became an artificial-intelligence trade in 2025 and the first half of 2026, and why the sector's multiple expanded on a demand narrative rather than an earnings one.

What changed in 2026 is the second half of the sentence. The authorised return is not automatic and the rate base is not self-approving. Every dollar of that \$1.3trn must pass a state commission that is now operating in a visibly hostile political environment. Roughly one in six American households entered 2026 behind on their utility bills; the National Energy Assistance Directors Association projected total arrears could reach \$25bn by the end of the year. Federal data released in April showed 94.9 million electricity customers received final disconnection notices in 2024, with power actually cut to 13.4 million households. Against that backdrop, an analysis of 110 investor-owned utilities found combined profits of \$186bn between 2021 and 2024 — about thirteen cents of every dollar customers paid.

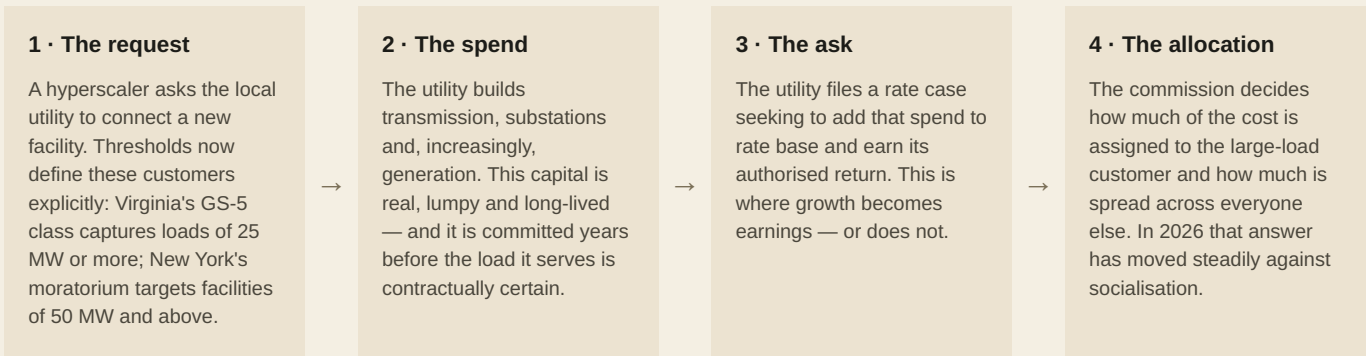
Those two facts sitting side by side — record arrears and record profits — are what converted a technical ratemaking question into an electoral one. A Gallup survey in March 2026 found seven in ten Americans opposed to data centre construction in their own communities. The watchdog group Data Center Watch counted at least 75 projects worth roughly \$130bn blocked or delayed by community pushback in the first quarter of 2026 alone. New York's executive order followed in July. The load is real; the licence to serve it profitably is now contested.

THE ESSENTIAL DISTINCTION

A merchant generator sells electricity to a data centre at a negotiated price and keeps the difference. A regulated utility spends shareholder capital to serve that same data centre and must then persuade a commission to let it earn a return. *Both are described as beneficiaries of AI power demand. Only one of them requires permission.*

MECHANISM

How one megawatt becomes an earnings question



Sources: Virginia State Corporation Commission GS-5 rate class, final order 25 November 2025, applying to loads of 25 MW and above; New York Executive Order No. 62, 14 July 2026, applying to hyperscale facilities of 50 MW and above. Sequence is a stylised description of standard US cost-of-service ratemaking, not a specific proceeding.

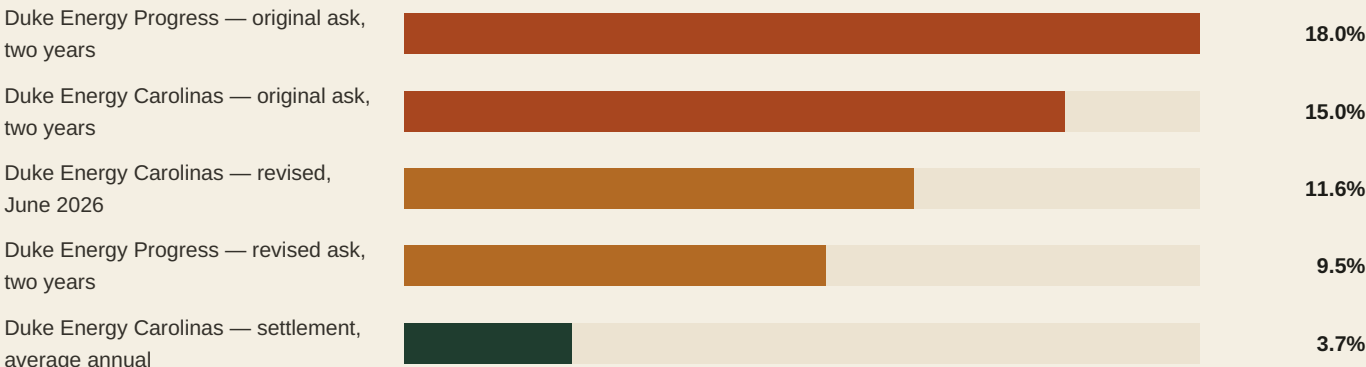


Figures as published on the dates shown. The Gallup and Data Center Watch figures are reported via Consumer Reports, 23 July 2026; the capital expenditure figure is S&P Global Market Intelligence's own projection and is a forecast, not an outcome.

THE CENTRAL COMPARISON

What was asked for, and what survived

The clearest available measure of the permission problem is the arc of a single set of rate cases. Duke Energy's two Carolinas utilities filed in late 2025 for substantial multi-year increases. Over roughly eight months of intervention by the North Carolina Attorney General, the Public Staff, environmental groups and organised ratepayers, both requests were cut repeatedly. Nothing about the underlying cost of the capital changed. What changed was the political price of collecting it.



Bars are illustrative and scaled to the largest original request; they compare figures drawn from different filings and are not strictly like-for-like. Sources: WFAE and WUNC, 20 July 2026, on the Duke Energy Carolinas settlement (original 15 per cent over two years, reduced to 11.6 per cent in June, settled at an average 3.7 per cent annual increase, subject to North Carolina Utilities Commission approval); Consumer Reports, 23 July 2026, and NC Newsline, 11 August 2026, on the Duke Energy Progress case (18 per cent over two years reduced to 9.5 per cent). Settlement terms reported include residential increases of 5.9 per cent in 2027 and 3.6 per cent in 2028 for Duke Energy Carolinas customers.

A USEFUL MENTAL MODEL

Treat a regulated utility's growth pipeline the way a lender treats an unsigned term sheet. The capital expenditure number is what the borrower would like to draw. The authorised return is the rate they hope to pay. *The commission is the credit committee — and it has begun declining lines it approved without argument two years ago.*

WHAT HAS ACTUALLY SHIFTED

Five changes, each cutting both ways

WHAT HAS CHANGED	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN THE DATA	WHY IT CUTS BOTH WAYS
Large loads have their own rate class	Virginia's SCC approved the GS-5 class for customers of 25 MW and above in a final order dated 25 November 2025, capturing most of the roughly 450 data centres Dominion already serves.	It protects the utility from a political backlash by making data centres pay their own way — but it also caps the amount of data centre capital that can be socialised into a growing rate base, which is where the earnings leverage lived.
Transmission costs are being directly assigned	On 5 August 2026 the Virginia SCC ordered Dominion to develop a tariff assigning transmission infrastructure costs directly to data centres and other large-load users.	Directly assigned cost is cleaner and less politically exposed, but it is also cost the utility recovers rather than cost it earns a spread on across a broad customer base.
Siting has become a veto point	New York's Executive Order No. 62 paused discretionary state environmental permits for hyperscale facilities for up to a year from 14 July 2026, with four such centres operating in the state and applications pending for thirty-nine more.	Constrained supply of sites raises the value of existing interconnected capacity and signed contracts — while removing the growth optionality that the same equities are partly valued on.
Capacity prices have repriced sharply	PJM's auction cleared at a record \$329.17/MW-day for the year from 1 June 2026, up 22 per cent, with the grid operator estimating bill increases of 1.5 to 5 per cent for some ratepayers depending on state.	Merchant generators capture that price directly. But the same number is the single most quotable piece of evidence for legislators arguing that the AI build-out is being paid for by households.
Rate cases now settle far below the ask	Duke Energy Carolinas' request fell from 15 per cent over two years to a settled average of 3.7 per cent a year across roughly eight months in 2026.	A settlement removes regulatory uncertainty and is often taken well by the market — but it resets the base from which the next request must be argued, in a state where the intervention machinery has now proved it works.

Both cases, built from the same external record

The bull case

- **The load is contracted, not speculative.** Constellation signed a 380 MW agreement with CyrusOne in Q1 2026 to serve a facility adjacent to its Freestone Energy Center in Texas, with an exclusive arrangement covering a further 380 MW phase — taking its Texas data centre commitments past 1,100 MW when combined with earlier deals.
- **Scarcity is being priced.** PJM's record \$329.17/MW-day clear, up 22 per cent and roughly eleven times the level of two years prior, is a direct cash transfer to owners of existing dispatchable capacity, achieved without a single rate case.
- **Regulators are protecting the utility, not just the ratepayer.** Virginia's GS-5 class and the August transmission-assignment order are designed to keep large-load costs off other customers — which is precisely what preserves a utility's social licence to keep building.
- **Constrained siting favours incumbents.** A moratorium on new hyperscale permits in New York and \$130bn of delayed projects elsewhere raise the scarcity value of sites already interconnected and generation already built.
- **Capital is being deployed at scale regardless.** Sector capital expenditure projected at \$227.8bn in 2026 and \$233bn in 2027 is rate base growth in the making, and rate base growth is the mechanical driver of regulated earnings.
- **Consolidation is being attempted at the top.** NextEra's proposed all-stock acquisition of Dominion, valued at roughly \$67bn and announced in May 2026, is a capital-markets vote that scale in regulated power is worth paying for.

The bear case

- **The permission constraint is now measurable.** Duke's Carolinas request fell from 15 per cent over two years to a settled 3.7 per cent average annual increase in about eight months. That is a 75 per cent haircut to the ask, arrived at through process, not politics alone.
- **Affordability has become an electoral variable.** One in six households behind on bills, projected arrears of \$25bn by end-2026, and 94.9 million final disconnection notices issued in 2024 make rate relief the cheapest thing a state politician can offer.
- **Cost assignment removes the leverage.** If data centres pay directly for their own transmission and generation, the utility becomes a contractor on those assets rather than an owner earning a spread on a growing base — the same volumes, a thinner economic claim on them.
- **Siting risk is now a legal fact, not a scenario.** New York has paused permits statewide for up to a year, is consulting on repealing data centre sales tax exemptions, and is considering a fund requiring data centres to pre-fund grid investment.
- **Rates are the wrong direction for a bond proxy.** The ten-year Treasury closed 1 September 2026 at 4.75 per cent, its highest since 15 January 2025, and the thirty-year at 5.243 per cent. Utilities are both discounted at those rates and funding an enormous capital programme at them.
- **The merger needs the sceptics' consent.** The NextEra–Dominion transaction requires approval from FERC and the commissions of Virginia, North Carolina and South Carolina — the same three states running the most contested large-load and rate proceedings in the country.

Neither case here is drawn from the internal Wiki, because the Wiki could not be reached on this run. Both were assembled from external reporting and from tensions visible inside the companies' own filings and settlements — the bear case in particular leans on the gap between what utilities asked regulators for and what they accepted, which is a matter of public record rather than interpretation.

WHERE THE VIEWS DIVERGE

An unresolved conflict

The clearest conflict this edition can name is between the market's framing and the regulatory record, and it is not resolved by anything currently available. Equity commentary through 2026 has consistently treated regulated utilities as an artificial-intelligence exposure — the sector's re-rating has been explained by data centre load, and a \$67bn acquisition has been proposed on that logic. The regulatory record points the other way: Virginia is assigning large-load costs directly to large loads, New York has paused new hyperscale permits and is examining a fund that would make data centres pre-finance grid upgrades, and North Carolina cut a headline rate request by roughly three quarters. If regulators succeed in insulating ordinary ratepayers from data centre costs, they will by construction have insulated utility shareholders from most of the upside too.

There is a second, sharper divergence internal to this firm's own recent output. The archive shows Field Guide editions on AI Capex on 4 August and Grid Equipment on 6 August 2026, both of which treated the power build-out primarily as

a demand opportunity. This edition, working only from external evidence, reaches a materially more constrained conclusion about who captures that demand. That tension is stated rather than settled: the internal reasoning behind those earlier editions could not be retrieved this run, so it would be improper to characterise, let alone rebut, it.

WHAT TO WATCH FROM HERE

A dashboard for the next quarter

SIGNAL	PLAIN-ENGLISH READING	WHY IT MATTERS
FOMC decision, 16 September 2026	Futures implied roughly a 57.5 to 58 per cent chance of a 25 basis point hike to 3.75–4.00 per cent as of 1 September, up from about 36 per cent before Chair Warsh's Jackson Hole remarks.	Utilities are discounted like bonds and funded like industrials. A hiking cycle raises the discount rate on the terminal value and the coupon on the build-out simultaneously.
Dominion's transmission cost tariff filing	The Virginia SCC's 5 August order requires a proposal assigning transmission costs directly to large-load users.	The design of that tariff is the clearest read yet on how much data centre infrastructure lands in rate base versus in a direct customer charge.
New York's Generic Environmental Impact Statement	The moratorium lifts only once the Department of Public Service completes the GEIS, a process budgeted at up to one year from 14 July 2026.	The standards it sets — on energy, water and ratepayer protection — become the template other states copy or reject.
North Carolina Utilities Commission ruling on the Duke settlement	The 3.7 per cent average annual settlement is agreed but not yet approved.	Approval confirms the intervention playbook works; rejection in either direction tells you where the true regulatory centre of gravity sits.
NextEra–Dominion approvals	The transaction requires FERC plus Virginia, North Carolina and South Carolina commission consent.	Conditions attached to approval — on rates, on large-load cost allocation, on capital plans — will be the most explicit statement regulators have yet made about acceptable returns.
The next PJM capacity auction	The 2026–27 clear was \$329.17/MW-day, capped; PJM estimated it would have reached nearly \$389 without the cap agreed with Pennsylvania's governor.	A second capped auction would confirm that political intervention has become a permanent feature of merchant power pricing, not a one-off.

THREE POSTURES, NOT ONE ANSWER

Coherent ways to hold this, and what each costs

Own the contract, not the permission Favour merchant and independent generators that sell contracted power directly to hyperscalers and are not dependent on a commission granting a return. The cost: these names carry commodity and counterparty risk, trade on multiples that already embed the scarcity story, and are exposed to federal decisions on co-location that have already moved against them once.	Own the regulated compounder anyway Accept the permission constraint and underwrite regulated utilities on rate base growth at a lower but more durable authorised return. The cost: the sector is discounted at long rates that are at multi-year highs, the capital programme must be funded into that, and every settlement resets the base for the next ask.	Own the spend, not the spender Take exposure to the equipment and engineering firms paid out of the \$1.3trn capital programme regardless of what return the utility is ultimately allowed to earn on it. The cost: this is a backlog business exposed to project cancellation and delay, and \$130bn of schemes were already blocked or delayed in a single quarter.
---	---	--

The companies named on the following page are illustrative of the mechanisms discussed in this edition. They are NOT recommendations, and no view on their valuation, suitability or prospects is expressed or implied.

Six ways the same load shows up

NEE

NextEra Energy

\$67bn all-stock bid
announced May 2026

The largest expression of the view that scale in regulated power is worth paying for. NextEra proposed acquiring Dominion in an all-stock transaction valued at roughly \$67bn, which would create the largest regulated electric utility in the United States. The logic is rate base: more approved capital, more authorised return. The structure makes the permission problem explicit, because the deal cannot complete without the consent of the very commissions currently tightening large-load cost allocation.

WATCH NEXT

Conditions attached by the Virginia, North Carolina and South Carolina commissions — the price of consent is the real headline.

D

Dominion Energy

GS-5 order 25 Nov 2025
transmission order 5 Aug 2026

The purest case study in the sector. Dominion already serves roughly 450 data centres in Virginia, the densest concentration in the world, and is now operating under a dedicated GS-5 rate class for customers of 25 MW and above. In August the SCC went further, ordering it to develop a tariff assigning transmission costs directly to large-load users. Dominion is simultaneously the biggest beneficiary of data centre load and the first utility to have that load formally ring-fenced from the rest of its customer base.

WATCH NEXT

The transmission tariff proposal itself — it is the template for how directly assigned large-load cost gets designed nationally.

DUK

Duke Energy

\$119.91 close
1 September 2026

The clearest evidence that the ask and the outcome have decoupled. Two Carolinas rate cases filed in late 2025 were cut repeatedly through 2026: Duke Energy Carolinas from 15 per cent over two years to 11.6 per cent in June and then to a settled 3.7 per cent average annual increase in July; Duke Energy Progress from 18 per cent to 9.5 per cent. The shares closed at \$119.91 on 1 September 2026, for a market capitalisation of about \$93.5bn.

WATCH NEXT

North Carolina Utilities Commission approval of the settlement, and whether residential steps of 5.9 and 3.6 per cent survive intact.

CEG

Constellation Energy

380 MW + 380 MW
CyrusOne, Q1 2026

The contracted-load model. In the first quarter of 2026 Constellation signed a 380 MW agreement with CyrusOne to connect and serve a new data centre adjacent to its Freestone Energy Center in Texas, plus an exclusive arrangement covering a second 380 MW phase — bringing its Texas data centre commitments above 1,100 MW alongside earlier deals. None of that revenue requires a state commission to authorise a return. It requires a counterparty to keep paying.

WATCH NEXT

Whether contracted volumes convert into disclosed multi-year pricing, or remain megawatt announcements without stated economics.

VST

Vistra Energy

Meta agreements
January 2026

A merchant fleet re-rated on multi-decade offtake. In January 2026 Vistra and Meta announced agreements supporting existing nuclear plants within the PJM footprint, including an option for Meta to take power from a potential new 300 MW small modular reactor at a Vistra site. Vistra also collects the record PJM capacity price directly. The same \$329.17/MW-day that flows to its revenue line is the number consumer advocates quote when arguing households are subsidising artificial intelligence.

WATCH NEXT

Whether PJM's next auction clears capped again — a second cap makes political price-setting structural rather than episodic.

TLN

Talen Energy

\$650m campus sale
to Amazon, March

The name that already met the regulatory ceiling once. Talen sold its data centre campus to Amazon for \$650m in March, in a first-of-its-kind arrangement powering the site from an adjacent nuclear plant. The broader co-location structure was subsequently disrupted when federal regulators rejected a key Amazon nuclear interconnection agreement, and Talen, Constellation and Vistra all fell on the news. It is the sharpest available reminder that even the unregulated route runs through a regulator eventually.

WATCH NEXT

Federal treatment of behind-the-meter co-location — the question that determines whether merchant nuclear can bypass the grid at all.

The bottom line

What was repriced in 2026 was not electricity demand. That was already understood, and the capital plans reflect it: \$227.8bn of sector capital expenditure this year, a pipeline near \$1.3trn to 2030, and a DOE estimate that data centres could take up to 15.3 per cent of US electricity by 2030. What was repriced was the assumption that this demand converts automatically into shareholder return. New York paused hyperscale permitting outright. Virginia built a separate rate class for large loads and then ordered transmission costs assigned directly to them. North Carolina cut a headline rate request by roughly three quarters through eight months of intervention. Each of those is a decision about who pays, and therefore about who earns.

The evidence is genuinely mixed and should not be flattened. Merchant generators are capturing record capacity prices and signing hundred-megawatt contracts without asking anyone's permission; a \$67bn acquisition has been proposed on the strength of regulated scale; and constrained siting plausibly raises the value of what is already built. The reasonable inference is narrower than either the bull or bear framing: the demand thesis has been substantially validated while the returns thesis has been quietly weakened, and the two are still being valued as though they were one thing. The next test is not a data point but a document — the tariff Dominion must file assigning transmission cost directly to large loads, which will show, in numbers, how much of the artificial-intelligence build-out a utility is actually allowed to own.

Editorial note. This is educational commentary prepared for internal use. It is not investment advice, not a recommendation, and not a solicitation to buy or sell any security. Companies named are illustrative of the mechanisms under discussion and were selected to span different structural positions within a single theme; no view on their valuation or suitability is expressed. All external figures carry an as-of date and reflect information available at that date; prices and regulatory positions change. In a normal edition, internal Heyokha Wiki views are attributed to the named research provider and labelled as that provider's opinion rather than as fact or forecast — **this edition contains no internal Wiki view at all, because the Wiki could not be reached**, and readers should weight it accordingly. Where internal and external views conflict, this publication states the conflict and leaves it unresolved rather than adjudicating it.

Sources and update notes

(a) Internal sources used: none. No internal Wiki page was consulted for this edition and no *last_reviewed* or *created* date can be cited, because the Heyokha Wiki MCP server was not present in this run's tool environment. Repeated tool-schema lookups for *mcp__Heyokha_Wiki__** returned no matching tools, so *list_sources*, *list_pages*, *get_page*, *get_relations* and *search_wiki* could not be called. No research provider — 13D Research, White Box, Greed & Fear, Solid Ground, Marc Faber, HS Dent, Gary Shilling or any other — is relied upon anywhere in this edition, and none should be inferred from its content.

(b) Limitation on the internal view. The standing limitation this section normally carries is provider concentration: a Wiki theme page typically leans on a small number of subscription research houses, whose shared priors are not visible in the page text. This edition's limitation is more severe and of a different kind — the internal view is entirely absent. The argument above therefore has no house-thesis anchor, no dated internal review, and no counterweight from the firm's own analysts. It is a synthesis of public reporting by an automated process, and it should be read as materially less authoritative than an edition carrying an attributed internal thesis. Its selection of evidence has not been checked against any internal position, and the external record it draws on is itself skewed toward consumer-advocacy and regulatory sources, which report the affordability side of this story more thoroughly than the utility-return side.

(c) External sources. (1) Office of Governor Kathy Hochul, press release and Executive Order No. 62, 14 July 2026: nation's first statewide moratorium on new hyperscale data centres, pausing discretionary state environmental permits for up to one year pending a Generic Environmental Impact Statement; targets facilities of 50 MW and above; also directs consideration of a New York Grid Acceleration Fund and pursuit of legislation repealing data centre sales tax exemptions. (2) Consumer Reports, "Inside the Energy Affordability Crisis", 23 July 2026: residential electricity rates up 7.3 per cent April 2025 to April 2026 per federal analysis; utilities requested \$18.6bn of rate increases in H1 2026 against \$29bn in all of 2025 and \$15bn in 2024, citing PowerLines Q2 2026; Gallup March 2026 finding that 7 in 10 Americans oppose local data centre construction; Data Center Watch Q1 2026 count of at least 75 projects worth about \$130bn blocked or delayed; 110 investor-owned utilities reporting \$186bn combined profit 2021–2024, about 13 cents per customer dollar, per Energy & Policy Institute March 2026; roughly 1 in 6 households behind on utility bills with NEADA projecting \$25bn of arrears by end-2026; federal data released April showing 94.9 million final disconnection notices in 2024 and 13.4 million households disconnected; Department of Energy estimate that data centres could reach 15.3 per cent of US electricity use by 2030; and the Duke Energy Progress request falling from 18 per cent to 9.5 per cent over two years. (3) PJM, news release, 14 July 2026, and Utility Dive: 2026/27 base residual auction cleared at a record \$329.17/MW-day, up 22 per cent year on year and roughly eleven times the level two years earlier, procuring 138,318 MW; PJM estimates bill impacts of 1.5 to 5 per cent for some ratepayers and that the price would have reached nearly \$389/MW-day without the cap agreed with Pennsylvania Governor Josh Shapiro. (4) Virginia State Corporation Commission: final order in the Dominion Energy Virginia biennial review dated 25 November 2025 approving the GS-5 rate class for customers demanding 25 MW or more, covering

most of the roughly 450 data centres Dominion serves; and order of 5 August 2026 directing Dominion to develop a policy directly assigning transmission infrastructure costs to data centres and other large-load users, reported by Virginia Mercury and Utility Dive. (5) WFAE, WUNC and BPR, 20 July 2026, and NC Newline, 11 August 2026: Duke Energy Carolinas' request reduced from an average 15 per cent over two years, to 11.6 per cent in June following intervention by Attorney General Jeff Jackson, to a settled average annual increase of 3.7 per cent over two years, with residential increases of 5.9 per cent in 2027 and 3.6 per cent in 2028, subject to North Carolina Utilities Commission approval. (6) Market data for the session of 1 September 2026, via CNBC and Zacks/Yahoo Finance market reports: Dow Jones Industrial Average -0.7 per cent to 53,185.90; S&P 500 -0.3 per cent to 7,686.14; Nasdaq Composite -0.1 per cent to 26,370.89; ten-year Treasury yield +2bp to 4.75 per cent, highest since 15 January 2025; thirty-year +3bp to 5.243 per cent; Utilities Select Sector SPDR -1 per cent; Technology Select Sector SPDR -1.6 per cent; Duke Energy closed at \$119.91 with a market capitalisation of about \$93.5bn. (7) CME FedWatch as reported 31 August and 1 September 2026: implied probability of a 25 basis point hike to 3.75–4.00 per cent at the 16 September FOMC of roughly 57.5 to 58 per cent, up from about 36 per cent before Chair Kevin Warsh's Jackson Hole speech of 28 August 2026; Barclays subsequently forecast two hikes. (8) S&P Global Market Intelligence, April 2026: US utility capital expenditure projected at \$227.8bn in 2026 and \$233bn in 2027, within a pipeline approaching \$1.3trn across 2026–2030. (9) Constellation Energy Form 10-Q for the period ended 30 June 2026 and associated reporting: 380 MW CyrusOne agreement at the Freestone Energy Center, Texas, signed in Q1 2026, with an exclusive arrangement for a further 380 MW phase, taking combined Texas data centre commitments above 1,100 MW. (10) Reporting on Vistra–Meta agreements announced January 2026 supporting existing PJM nuclear plants, including an option for a potential 300 MW small modular reactor; on Talen Energy's \$650m sale of a data centre campus to Amazon in March; and on the share-price falls at Talen, Constellation and Vistra following federal rejection of a key Amazon nuclear co-location agreement. (11) Reporting on NextEra Energy's proposed all-stock acquisition of Dominion Energy, announced May 2026 at approximately \$67bn, requiring FERC approval and consent from the Virginia, North Carolina and South Carolina commissions.

(d) Editorial choices in this automated run. Two tool failures shaped this edition and both are material. First, the remote-devices bridge specified for archive access was absent; the *HB Wiki Learning* folder was instead read directly through the session's mounted workspace, so the cooldown check is *complete and verified* rather than degraded — thirty prior editions were parsed into date and topic, and the thirty-day cooldown set covering 3 August to 1 September 2026 comprises Copper, AI Capex, Gold Miners, Grid Equipment, Oil & Gas, Software Unit Economics, Healthcare Rotation, Tanker Shipping, Uranium, Oil Chokepoint Risk, Seat-Based Software, Energy Chokepoints, Copper Smelting Bottleneck, Fiscal Dominance, China Equities, Memory Supercycle, Rare Earth Magnets, Gold, Humanoid Robots, Iran War, Coal, Grain Supply Shock and Yen Carry Trade. Second, and more seriously, the Heyokha Wiki MCP server was not available, so the prescribed topic-selection procedure — scoring entities by recency and title appearance across sources published in the last twenty-one days, then filtering the active theme universe — could not be run. Topic selection fell back to external research, as the instructions direct. Power Affordability was chosen because it carries a live, dated catalyst (the 16 September FOMC decision against a backdrop of record capacity prices and active rate proceedings), because the regulatory record supplies unusually well-documented primary sources, and because it is the sharpest theme in the current tape that does not appear anywhere in the verified thirty-day cooldown set. It is adjacent to two cooled topics — AI Capex and Grid Equipment — and that adjacency is acknowledged rather than hidden; the framing here is deliberately the inverse of a demand-growth edition, addressing cost allocation and permitted return rather than load. Because no Wiki page could be retrieved, the internal-versus-external conflict required by the house format was constructed from two external strands plus the observable framing of prior editions in the archive, which is a weaker construction than the format intends. A reader wanting the house view on this theme should treat this edition as a prompt to consult the Wiki directly rather than as a substitute for it.